

From Japan to the West and now gathering pace in India, cosplaying is far more than just nerds being nerds

By Manish "Trigger Happy" Rajesh



you're a geek or belong to any kind of geeky fandom, you're probably familiar with or have

heard of the term cosplay. Cosplay first started or originated in Japan, the cosplay culture there is huge and became extremely popular throughout the country come the 90s. Ever since Japanese culture took the world by storm, their music, their anime, their manga, and yes, even their cosplay have become a phenomenon of sorts throughout the world.

Cosplay right now is in a rather unique position. It's something that many look down upon and shun, but at the same time it's something many people love. There's those that live and breathe cosplay and there's those that despise it and think it silly and childish. Then there's also those that accept it for what it is, because whether you like it or not, cosplay is here to stay. It's a fundamental part of every geeky con-

vention, in fact if you aren't wearing some sort of costume at these events, you're probably the one who's in the minority. Cosplay has become a huge subculture in the geek world and is now essentially synonymous with the idea of any gathering of geeks or a geeky convention.

Cosplay is a play on words and is derived from two words – costume and play. Which makes sense because that's pretty much what it is. You play the role of the fictional character you're attempting to portray with your costume. It's a pretty simple concept. You aren't just dressing up as the character, you're becoming the character.

We've got a surprisingly large number of geeks in our country. We've got every kind of geek, from avid comic book readers, to hardcore anime fans, TV show buffs, and even a gaming community that's growing fast. So we're bound to have a few cosplayers as well, right? So we reached out to

some of the best cosplayers in our country to find out more about cosplay and what it entails.

THE ORIGINS

So we asked them why it was that they cosplayed and what was it that inspired them to start. Rhea, one of the cosplayers we got in touch with said that it had always been her dream to "meet a fictional character". Well that's a dream a lot of us shared, we've all wanted to meet Superman or Batman at some point in our lives. Of course it's not limited to just Superman and Batman, it could be Goku from the Dragonball series, or Naruto from.. err Naruto, or Dante from Devil may cry, it could be anyone really, we don't judge. Just like Rhea we've all been through that Peter Parker phase where we've thought up imaginary superhero names for ourself and designed ourselves a neat little costume in our head. We've imagined ourselves with superpowers and what we'd

Tricks of the trade

The SkunkWorks guys specialise in building props, and as you'll soon find out, props are a fundamental part of any cosplay. So if you want to dip your hands into the world of cosplay, you'd better figure out how to make yourself some props and what it'll entail. Scythes Skunkworks were kind enough to give us some pointers in the art of prop building, so pay attention if you're hoping to do some prop building of your own.

Using the Prop - Think ahead, do you think you'll be using it in a crowded place? Or are you maybe using it for a more private event or location which



won't be too crowded. Also keep in mind whether you will be travelling with it over long distances or not (Does it need to be dismantlable?).

Quality of the Prop - The choice of material will greatly affect the life of the prop. So if you spend a little more on better quality, your prop will last longer.

Monies !! - The time, the tools, and the materials, including travelling expenses to acquire those materials, needs to be taken into consideration when planning a budget yourself. You can be creative and save yourself on some spending.